

ONGOING COVID-19 SYMPTOMS

- Manage the patient with COVID-19 symptoms that have lasted for more than 4 weeks.
- Common ongoing symptoms include: tiredness, breathlessness, cough, smell/taste abnormalities, headache, dizziness, cognitive slowing ('brain fog'), joint/muscle pain and chest pain.
- Confirm that patient had COVID-19: either positive COVID-19 test or a typical history of COVID-19. If no positive test and uncertain about COVID-19 history, discuss with specialist.

Give urgent attention to the patient with ongoing COVID-19 symptoms and any of:

- Respiratory rate ≥ 25
- Oxygen saturation $< 95\%$
- Temperature $\geq 38^{\circ}\text{C}$
- Pulse rate > 120
- BP $< 90/60$
- Headache with vomiting
- Severe or new chest pain $\hookrightarrow 37$
- New sudden asymmetric weakness or numbness of face, arm or leg; difficulty speaking or visual disturbance: consider **stroke** or **TIA** $\rightarrow 136$
- If difficulty breathing worse on lying flat and leg swelling, **heart failure** likely $\hookrightarrow 135$
- Decreased consciousness or new onset confusion/agitation
- Coughing up fresh blood
- Swollen painful calf

Manage and refer urgently $\hookrightarrow 38$.

Approach to the patient with ongoing COVID-19 symptoms not needing urgent attention:

- If known with a chronic condition, check control and give routine care.
- Test for TB if current cough, weight loss $\geq 1.5\text{kg}$, drenching night sweats, fever or fatigue: send 1 sputum sample for TB NAAT $\hookrightarrow 92$.
- If stress, anxiety or low mood, assess and manage further $\hookrightarrow 86$.

Ask about duration of symptoms:

< 2 months

≥ 2 months

- Reassure that many people have ongoing COVID-19 symptoms, even in mild cases.
- Explain that symptoms usually resolve slowly with time.
- Advise to rest and pace activity.
- Treat pain with **paracetamol** 1g 4-6 hourly (up to 4g in 24 hours) or **ibuprofen** 400mg 8 hourly with food as needed for up to 5 days.
- Extend sick leave as needed.

- If symptoms persist, advise to return for review.
- Advise when to return urgently: see red box below.

First check for pregnancy, HIV, diabetes and anaemia:

Check for pregnancy

If woman of child bearing age, exclude pregnancy $\hookrightarrow 157$.

Check for HIV

If HIV status is unknown or negative, test for HIV $\hookrightarrow 110$.

Check for diabetes

Check fingerprick glucose and interpret $\hookrightarrow 17$.

Check for anaemia

Check fingerprick Hb. If < 12 (woman) or < 13 (man), anaemia likely $\hookrightarrow 27$.

If chest pain, joint pain, headache, dizziness, manage as on symptom pages.

If none of above or symptoms persist despite treatment, **Long COVID** likely, give routine care $\hookrightarrow 121$.

Advise to return urgently if breathlessness worsens, new or worsening confusion or unable to wake patient, chest pain or pressure that won't go away, new sudden weakness or numbness in face, leg or arm.